

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 3 · 31 July 2026 · Complimentary — please take one bubbletea.nz · est. 2026



BREAKING · GROVER STREET

Mascot Costume Count Triples in Nine Days, Risk Assessed Moderate

Case definition: any shopfront fielding a staffed, waist-to-ceiling costumed beverage mascot during trading hours. Six confirmed shopfronts as of Tuesday, up from two the previous Friday. The street association's newsletter has requested "a moratorium on escalation, or at minimum, a lane for pedestrians."

community-outbreak-bulletin

EDITORIAL · MENACE WATCH, DEBUT COLUMN

The Fetchly Mascot: Hero or Menace?

Gordon Slate, Editor-in-Chief

Spotted for the third day running weaving a delivery e-bike through the parade crowd: a rider in a full-body lightning-bolt costume for the Fetchly app, steadying a toddler's dropped ice cream before it hit the pavement — helpful, some will say. This paper caught the mask again off-shift at Re:Burger, working through a stack of hamburgers, head tucked under one arm. Refuelling for what? Nobody at Fetchly will confirm the rider's name, and a masked figure who won't explain his own lunch order is a menace with a delivery quota, now with a taste for beef. Fifty dollars and a lifetime pearl-milk-tea card to the first reader who photographs that face. (Disclosure: Fetchly delivered my own lunch Tuesday. Same costume. I tipped well. This changes nothing.)

GOSSIP · KISS & TELL

The Mascots Are Dating, Darling

The Stickybeak

Darling, the Grover Street mascot war has a subplot the shopfronts aren't advertising: the Cup and the Straw — yes, the two costumes glaring at each other from opposite footpaths every lunch hour — are, your Stickybeak can reveal, dating. Sources close to the foam padding confirm they carpool. The rivalry, loves, is entirely for the customers.



FIELD DISPATCH · THE WORLD BULLETIN

Live From the Parade Route, More or Less Upright

Eleven costumed mascots stepped off at noon in good order. A gust dusted the notes with what proved to be glitter, not a structural concern. Then the tapioca-pearl-backpack mascot's seam gave way, scattering actual bean bags at ankle height across the entire footpath — and Baxter Kline, still narrating evenly mid-sentence about "unprecedented civic enthusiasm for novelty beverage costuming," went down with the camera crew, live, on air.

Baxter Kline — "This has been The World Bulletin. I'm Baxter Kline, and — I believe I am currently wearing someone else's mascot head."

RURAL REPORT · THE RIDGELINE WEEKLY

Doyle Edges Higgins on Pasture Cover, First Time Since Autumn

Clem Whitlock

Doyle's back paddock came in at 2,450 kg DM/ha this week — a good forty kilos ahead of Higgins off the same soil type, first time Doyle's led since the autumn rotation. Higgins isn't worried, mind, just resting stock off a wetter block. Down in town they're getting worked up over people dressed as teacups; out here, forty kilos of dry matter is still the biggest story going.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA

Did You Know?

The word "boba" is Hong Kong slang, not Taiwanese — a playful Cantonese nickname for something round and plump. In Taiwan, where the drink was actually invented, the pearls are usually just called zhenzhu (pearls) or fenyuan.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle

Fresh local trivia

A rotating cast of columnists

Local ad space, weekly

Menace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

"I believe I am currently wearing someone else's mascot head."

— Baxter Kline, The World Bulletin, moments before regaining his own

JOKE OF THE WEEK

Why don't bubble tea baristas ever get lost? They always know how to read the leaves.



THE SILENT MAJORITY REPORT

On the Matter of the Grover Street Parade

They will tell you a street parade of costumed beverage mascots is a trivial matter, unworthy of comment. I have found, in my experience, that the press reliably underestimates precisely the things the great silent majority actually notices — they noticed Checkers, they noticed the tapes, they will notice a giant foam cup blocking the footpath outside their own shop. Let the commentators sneer. I will say this much, and it is not nothing: a nation that can still organize eleven mascots into a straight line on a Tuesday retains more institutional discipline than certain foreign ministries I could name, and did, at length, in 1972.

Richard Nixon



FOOD & DRINK · THE LASAGNA STANDARD

Grover Street's Pop-Up Tea Stand: Three Lasagnas, Reluctantly

Jon dragged me to the mascot parade under the pretense of "fun family day," which is Jon-speak for free labor holding his jacket. The pop-up tea stand redeemed the outing somewhat: their brown sugar boba had real weight to it, the dense, unhurried sweetness I respect in a beverage and refuse to respect in a salad. Three lasagnas, docked one full lasagna because they ran out of oversized cups by the time I, personally, arrived — a scheduling failure on their part, not a portion issue on mine. Odie tried to eat the straw. Odie did not review well either.

Garfield



MARKET RESEARCH · THE PEARL INDEX

Brown Sugar Holds, Matcha Splits the Room

Fieldwork: Grover Street parade weekend, 25–26 July, counter-side paper ballot, one flavor per patron, n=530, ±4.3% MOE. Brown Sugar Boba takes it at 31% — the Brown Sugar Loyalists turned out in force, as always — ahead of Taro (24%) and Wintermelon (19%). Most polarizing flavor: Matcha Latte, ranked dead last overall at 6%, yet the outright #1 pick among Sweetness-Level Independents, who describe it, correctly, as "zero sugar and proud of it." One Queue Abstainer admitted voting twice, "because the line for the ballot box was too long to check." The data doesn't lie. The patrons, on the other hand, absolutely do — that's what we build the trap questions for.

Priya Anand, Founder & Chief Analyst, The Pearl Index

IN MEMORIAM

The Un-Costumed Lunch Rush

Skeletor

There was a time, not so long ago, when a bubble tea counter needed no mascot to draw a queue. That time has passed, buried under six shopfronts' worth of foam and lightning bolts. I do not take credit for the escalation. I take, at most, mild credit for suggesting to one shopfront owner, in passing, that her rival "seemed to be doing rather well lately." The rest, apparently, followed on its own. Mourn the plain lunch hour if you must. Its replacement has considerably better security around the register.

MARKET WATCH · THE TRADING FLOOR

A Position Built Like a Cathedral

Sherman McCoy

From the thirty-first floor you could see the whole absurd parade of Grover Street mascots trooping past like tribute — a fitting view, he thought, for a man who had that morning built a position so architecturally sound that lesser traders would study it for years without grasping its symmetry. A modest short against a modest bond, nothing dramatic — and yet, watching it move eleven basis points his way by lunch, he found himself checking, twice, whether the Degrassi account had noticed. It hadn't yet. It would.



PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

The Grover Street Line-Up

Last week's Counter Queue only had room to print three of its clues: Priya orders a Large; the grass-jelly order is smaller than Quinn's; Quinn doesn't order pearls. That's enough to rule pearls and grass jelly out for Quinn outright and fix Priya's size — but the rest of the grid ran off the edge of the galley before deadline, so, same honest gap as Issue 1's fourth drink, I won't invent the missing names and sizes here. Reset and reprinted properly whenever it next runs.

- 1. Cup is not first in line.
- 2. Straw is somewhere ahead of Pearl.
- 3. Pearl is not last in line.

Brisk warm-up · Answer in next week's edition — Ken Endo

LIFESTYLES · CHAMPAGNE WISHES

Inside the Ashgrove-Pemberton Boba Pavilion

Robin Leach

Champagne wishes and caviar dreams, darlings — and this week they come garnished with tapiocal Property magnate Beau Ashgrove-Pemberton has unveiled, on the grounds of his Riviera-adjacent estate, a fully staffed bubble tea pavilion: a solid-brass boba fountain, hand-blown glass straws imported from Murano, and a mascot costume for the pavilion's own beverage butler, stitched from actual silk. He simply couldn't resist, he tells me, after seeing a street parade on the news and thinking, why not us, but bigger? Champagne wishes, caviar dreams, and now, apparently, tapioca ones too!

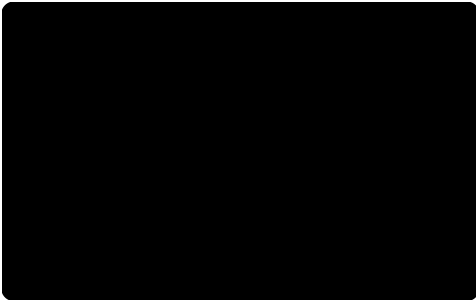


WEATHER DESK

Parade-Day Outlook: A Sky That Knows Exactly What It's Doing

Dana Foley (with Trent)

High of 17, a gentle nor'wester at 12 km/h, 10% chance of passing cloud — and that cloud knows the parade route better than the organizers do. It has been circling the harbour since dawn, patient, waiting to see if eleven costumed mascots really think they can cross open footpath without so much as a courtesy glance skyward. Trent, at the sports desk, has already asked twice if we can "just say it's nice out." We cannot, Trent. Nothing about a sky this quiet is nice. It is coiled. Stay dry, stay alert, I'll see you at six.



ASK THE CAPTAIN

Left Ashore

Horatio McCallister

"Everyone at work is coupled up except me and it's starting to feel deliberate." Left Ashore, the sea does not owe every vessel a matching pair at dock, and neither does the calendar. I've sailed alone longer than I've sailed accompanied, and I'll tell ye the alone stretches build the better captain. Stop counting other ships' rigging. Mind your own hull. Fair winds. Arrrr.

THE BOBA SIDE

IMAGE-GENERATION PROMPT — NOT RENDERED ARTWORK

Prompt: Seinen action gag-manga panel; bold sharp linework with heavy cross-hatching; black and white with one spot color (mascot-lightning-bolt yellow); Berserk-adjacent dramatic intensity; unhinged-serious atmosphere; screentone texture on shadows, dramatic speed lines. Six costumed mascot characters squared off in a low-angle standoff on the sidewalk at high noon, foam padding rustling ominously, one bubble tea cup rolling untouched between them like a showdown prop.

"ONLY ONE SHOPFRONT WOULD SURVIVE LUNCH RUSH."

The Boba Side — prompt script, awaiting illustration